

Project: Federico-Tena World Population Historical Database

Web site: <https://www.uc3m.es/investigacion/federico-tena-population>

Description of the project: Project developed by Giovanni Federico (New York University Abu Dhabi) and Antonio Tena-Junguito (Universidad Carlos III de Madrid).

We have estimated yearly series of total population for all polities (colonies and independent countries) from 1800 to 1938. Overall, the data-base features 174 series for a total of 21815 country-year observations. We have relied mainly on work by historical demographers, who have painstakingly collected, assessed and, when necessary, corrected official data and any available information. We have filled gaps with interpolations and have extrapolated backward the population from the earliest available figure to 1800 or forward from the latest one to 1938. We have taken also into account the population movements in neighboring or otherwise comparable polities and also the available information on demographic crises (most notably the Spanish flu). The country data refer to present (de facto) population when possible, adjusted to mid-year.

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Dataset content: Our new estimate of world population by countries are annual series ranging from 1800 to 1938. We organize the data set by continent and single excel (and txt) files by polities (that is more specific than countries) in thousand people (000).

Methodology and Sources: We have estimated population for a total of 21815 polity/year observations for 174 polities at their historical borders between 1800 and 1838. We detail the sources and methods of estimation and criteria used in: Federico, Giovanni; Tena-Junguito, Antonio (2023): How many people on earth? World

population 1800-1938. *Working Papers in Economic History* 23-02/ Instituto Figuerola Universidad Carlos III de Madrid. URI: <http://hdl.handle.net/10016/36431>

Time series coverage. In general terms, the data cover the period 1800-1938. They all include natives, as their omission would bias upward the growth of population and refer to current borders – so that some series cover only part of the period (e.g. Austria-Hungary stops in 1918, Czechoslovakia, Hungary and Poland start in 1919).

Geographical coverage: The minimal geographical units are the countries, when they have political independence, otherwise they are mentioned by the current name used by metropolitan political imperial or colonial administrative political units. The number of polities varies only as a consequence of changes in political boundaries.

File content: World file includes continents or polities units in Excel files ranked in alphabetical order according to current borders and historical names.

Keywords: World Population, Population by countries, New estimation Demographic transition

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Access use and privacy: The data will be reachable without restrictions under the terms of the license CC - BY. <https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>

The dataset contents:

Title:

Federico-Tena World Population Historical Database: Africa

Files:

africa_1800-1938_FTWPHD_2026_v01.xlsx = data

africa_1800-1938_FTWPHD_2026_v01_readme.pdf = documentation

Temporal coverage: 1800-1938

Spatial coverage: Africa

Sources:

[WP: <http://hdl.handle.net/10016/36431>]

New Sources in 2026 came from Version 4 of African Population Database 1850-1960
<https://www.aehnetwork.org/data-research/african-population-database-1850-1960/>
Frankema, E. and Jerven, M. (2014). 'Writing History Backwards and Sideways: Towards
a Consensus on African Population, 1850-present'. *Economic History Review* 67(S1):
907-931.

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